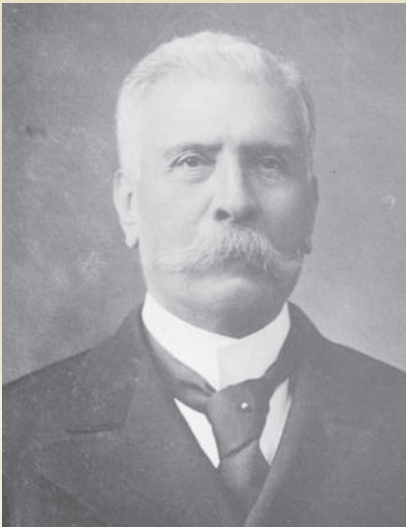




Face of the "Porfiriato"

General Porfirio Díaz (1830–1915) seized power in 1876. His government, known as the *Porfiriato*, was economically successful, but his rigging of the 1910 general election led to his overthrow in 1911.

1867 Mexico City recaptured by Benito Juárez. Maximilian shot.

1876 Porfirio Díaz president. Economic growth; rail system built.

1901 First year of oil production.

1910–20 Mexican Revolution provoked by the perceived exclusion from power of the middle classes and desire for land reform among peasants; 250,000 killed in this long-running and brutal civil war.

1911 Díaz overthrown by Francisco Madero. Guerrilla war breaks out in north. Emiliano Zapata leads peasant revolt in the south.

1913 Madero murdered. He is replaced by his chief of staff, General Victoriano Huerta. He faces opposition from Zapata in the south, Pancho Villa in the north, and from within his own elite from Venustiano Carranza.

1914 President Wilson of the US intervenes in the civil war by deposing General Huerta, whom he distrusts. Wilson also sends warships to Tampico and troops to Veracruz in order to safeguard US interests in Mexico.

1917 New constitution limits power of the Church. Mineral and subsoil rights reserved for the nation. Carranza becomes first president under the new constitution.

1919 Zapata is assassinated under Carranza's orders. Carranza is himself murdered a year later on the orders of his own army commander, Álvaro Obregón, who assumes the presidency. Villa is murdered in 1923.

1926–29 Cristero rebellion led by militant Catholic priests.

1929 National Revolutionary Party (later the Institutional Revolutionary Party, PRI) is formed.

1934 General Cárdenas president. Land reform accelerated, cooperative farms established, railroads nationalized, and US and UK oil companies expelled.

1940s US war effort helps Mexican economy grow.

1946 Election of Miguel Alemán as PRI president is opposed unsuccessfully by the last military rebellion in Mexico's history. Alemán's pro-business administration begins period of economic prosperity known as the "Mexican Miracle."

1968 An uprising by students in Mexico City results in a bloody massacre.

1970 Accelerating population growth reaches 3 percent a year.

1982 Mexico declares it cannot repay its foreign debt of over \$800 billion.

1984 Government contravenes constitution by relaxing laws on foreign investment.

1985 Earthquake in Mexico City. Official death toll 7,000. Economic cost estimated at \$425 million.

1988 Carlos Salinas de Gortari, minister of planning during the earthquake, is elected president.

1990 Privatization program begins.

1994–95 Guerrilla rebellion in southern Chiapas state by the Zapatista National Liberation Army (EZLN) for Amerindian rights is brutally suppressed by the army with at least 100 killed. Mexico joins North American Free Trade Agreement (NAFTA). PRI presidential candidate Luis Colosio murdered. Ernesto Zedillo replaces him and is elected. Economic crisis.

1997 Watershed elections; end of PRI's monopoly on power in Congress.

1999 Austerity budget and controversial bail-out of the banking system approved with the support of the National Action Party (PAN).

2000 PAN wins presidency and elections, ending 70 years of PRI rule. President Vicente Fox takes office, promising an end to corruption.

2001 EZLN guerrillas make 16-day motorcade from Chiapas to Mexico City to push for an indigenous rights law.

2006 In contested elections, PRI collapses to become the third political force after PAN and the Party of the Democratic Revolution (PRD). In the concurrent presidential election, PAN's Felipe Calderón wins by a tiny margin over the PRD's Andrés Manuel López Obrador.

2009 H1N1 "Swine flu" is first identified in Mexico and spreads worldwide.

«210–13 Pre-Columbian Americas
«214–15 Aztec to Inca
«318–19 Latin America Liberated

Guatemala



The largest and most populous of the states on the Central American isthmus.

c.250–900 CE Maya city-states flourish in modern-day southern Mexico and Central America. Maya civilization collapses as the cities are abandoned in the 8th and 9th centuries.

1524 The Spaniards set foot in Guatemala and in 1526 incorporate it into the Viceroyalty of New Spain.

1821 As a regional capital of the Viceroyalty of New Spain, Guatemala proclaims its independence.

1823 Guatemala, along with El Salvador, Honduras, Nicaragua, and Costa Rica reaffirm their independence as the United Provinces of Central America.

1838 Guatemala leaves the United Provinces to become an independent republic.

1944 General Jorge Ubico Castañeda, who took power in 1931, is overthrown in a popular uprising. Liberal reformer Juan José Arévalo wins the subsequent 1945 election.

1951 Jacobo Arbenz Guzmán is elected president and in 1952 introduces land reform and social reform measures.

1954 US-backed coup topples reformist Arbenz government.

1966–84 Counter-insurgency war; "pacification" of the highland Amerindians by the army; 200,000 die.

1986 Return of civilian rule; Marco Vinicio Cerezo Arévalo elected president.



US-sponsored coup

The CIA backed the coup of 1954 that overthrew President Arbenz after plantations run by the US-owned United Fruit Company were expropriated. The coup (above) led to 30 years of military rule.

1991 Jorge Antonio Serrano elected president but flees country after abortive "self-coup" in 1993.

1996 President Álvaro Arzú elected; peace deal with the Guatemalan National Revolutionary Unity (URNG) guerrillas ends 36 years of civil war.

1999 Truth Commission blames army and paramilitary allies for almost all human rights abuses during the civil war.

2005 Floods and mudslides caused by tropical storm Stan kill 1,500 people.

2007 Alvaro Colom of the center-left National Unity of Hope Party is elected president.

«74–75 People of the Jaguar
«210–13 Pre-Columbian Americas
«214–15 Aztec to Inca

Belize



Formerly British Honduras, Belize was the last country in the region to gain independence.

1670 Spain, the colonial power in Central America, recognizes certain British rights in the uninhabited area then bordered by the Sarstoon River.

1798 Spain, which continues to claim sovereignty, is defeated at the battle of St. George's Cay.

1802 British sovereignty over the colony is recognized by the Peace of Amiens.

1821 Guatemala claims sovereignty over the territory.

1862 The area becomes a British crown colony known as British Honduras.

1919 Demands for more rights by black Belizeans returning from World War I.

1936 New constitution with limited franchise introduced.

1950 People's United Party formed; voting age qualification for women reduced from 30 to 21.

1954 Full adult suffrage.

1972 Guatemala threatens invasion. Britain sends troops.

1981 Full independence.

1998 People's United Party wins crushing general election victory.

2000 Guatemala revives claim to half of the country.

2003 Guatemala rejects draft treaty aimed at settling border dispute.

«230–31 Contact Americas
«230–31 The Great Food Exchange